

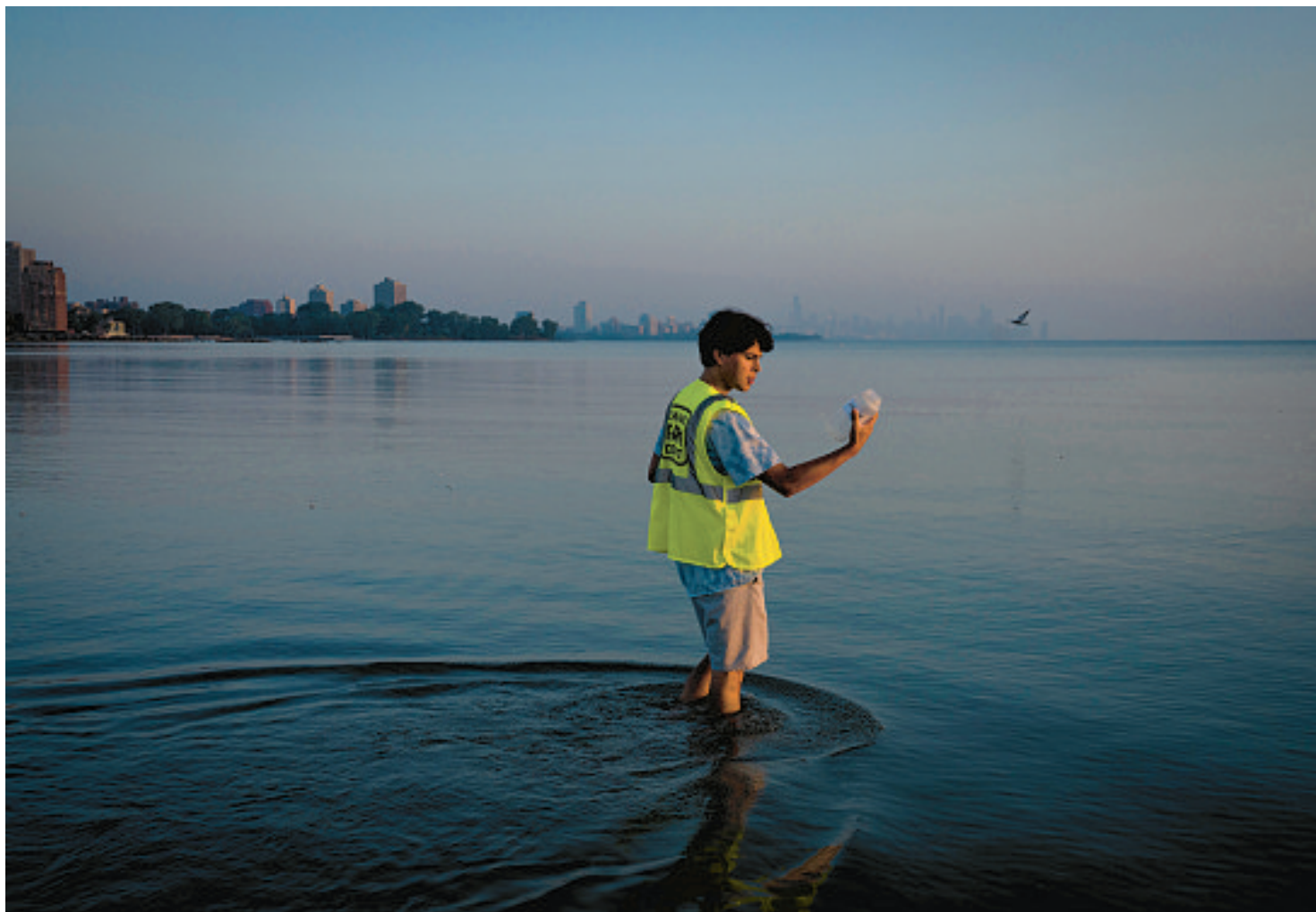
Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Invisible hazard can lurk beneath the Great Lakes

Bacteria closed hundreds of beaches in 2024. Now a program that helps monitor the levels faces a funding cut

Above: UIC student Andre Mejía collects water samples on Aug. 8 at Rainbow Beach as part of a collaboration between UIC and the Chicago Park District to have water tested. The results allow the Park District to relay the most up-to-date water quality conditions on its website and through a color-coded flag system. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

August is the best time of the year to take a dip in Lake Michigan, when its waters hover in the balmy upper 60s. Experts say so, and Chicago's crowded beaches offer proof. But an invisible hazard can quickly turn a sunny day out into a sick night in.

In 2024, over 300 beaches across the Great Lakes closed to visitors or issued swim bans or advisories due to the presence of bacteria in the water — mostly *E. coli*, from nearby surface runoff or sewer system overflows, especially during heavy rain — according to state

and federal data.

Bacteria levels triggered 83 advisories or closures in Illinois last summer, making it the second worst in the Midwest, with 71 in Lake County's 13 lakefront beaches and 12 across nine beaches in Cook County. As of Thursday, Lake County beaches have had 49 advisories this summer, according to data from the state's Department of Public Health. There has been at least one beach advisory in Cook County so far, according to Evanston officials.

"What we want, really want, to see is not that people say, 'Well, that's just the way it is.' It shouldn't have to be this way," said Nancy Stoner, senior attorney

at the Environmental Law and Policy Center, who focuses on clean water issues. "It's pollution that can be controlled and should be controlled, because people deserve to be able to know that they can swim safely in the Great Lakes."

In Wisconsin, 90 beaches closed or had advisories between May and September 2024 — representing the most lakefront locations affected — followed by Illinois, Ohio with 67, Michigan with 62, Indiana with 20 and Minnesota with 17, according to data from the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency's Beach Advisory and

Turn to Lakes, Page 2

Insurers propose big price increases

Consumers may face double-digit hikes for ACA exchange plans

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Illinois consumers may face sticker shock when they shop for health insurance plans on the state's Affordable Care Act exchange this fall — with most companies proposing double-digit-percentage price increases as they grapple with uncertainty about changes at the federal level.

Blue Cross and Blue Shield of Illinois, which has 238,000 Illinois residents on its exchange plans, is proposing an average rate increase of 27% across its individual exchange plans in Illinois.

UnitedHealthcare of Illinois, which has about 32,000 Illinois residents on its exchange plans, is proposing an average rate increase of nearly 21%.

Celtic Insurance Co.'s most recently submitted proposal would raise rates by an average of nearly 39%. Celtic has about 111,000 Illinois residents on its Ambetter exchange plans.

Several insurers are also pulling out of the exchange in Illinois for 2026. Aetna CVS Health, Health Alliance and Quartz will no longer offer exchange plans in Illinois next year, and Cigna Healthcare of Illinois will no longer sell marketplace plans in Cook County, though Cigna plans will be available in other parts of the state.

In filings with the state, insurance companies blamed the price increases on growing health care costs and increasing use of health care services. They also assumed in their calculations that enhanced tax credits that many people now use to help lower their monthly premiums for exchange plans will expire at the end of this year — a

Turn to Insurance, Page 4

Appeals court erases Trump's fraud penalty

Potential payout of \$527M for NY civil case called excessive

By Jennifer Peltz and Michael R. Sisak
Associated Press

NEW YORK — A New York appeals court on Thursday threw out the massive financial penalty a state judge imposed on President Donald Trump, while narrowly upholding a finding he engaged in fraud by exaggerating his wealth for decades. The ruling spares Trump from a potential half-billion dollar fine but bans him and his two eldest sons from serving in corporate leadership for a few years.

Trump, in a social media post, claimed "total victory."

"I greatly respect the fact that the Court had the Courage to throw out this unlawful and disgraceful Decision that was hurting Business all throughout New York State," he wrote.

The decision came seven months after the Republican returned to the White House. A sharply divided panel of five judges in New York's midlevel Appellate Division couldn't agree on many issues raised in Trump's appeal, but a majority said the monetary penalty was "excessive."

After finding Trump flagrantly padded financial statements that went to lenders and insur-

Turn to Trump, Page 8



People carry their stroller up stairs in the Sheridan Red Line "L" station in Uptown in Chicago on Thursday. The station hasn't been upgraded like some others have. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Tax district's bounty creates a bind

City must decide if CTA keeps getting cash or if it should be recouped

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

City Hall will soon have a far-reaching decision on its hands: How to dispose of a huge, growing pot of taxpayer money collecting in a North Side special taxing district that has quickly outperformed expectations.

The district has already taken in just under \$400 million since 2017. It is on track to pay off a major facelift of four Chicago Transit Authority stations and

the century-old infrastructure connecting them way ahead of schedule and estimated to bring in just shy of \$100 million annually by 2031.

The billion-dollar question is whether the CTA will keep receiving cash infusions from the district to help pay for future projects once the first phase is paid off, or if the money will instead be recouped by the city and other taxing bodies that are facing their own looming budget catastrophes.

Thanks to the rapid rise of property values within its boundaries, the "Red and Purple Modernization Phase One" tax increment financing district is on

IN BUSINESS: RTA officials agree to transfer \$74M from Metra and Pace to the CTA to help delay city service cuts.

pace to pay off the \$625 million earmarked for the first phase of overhauls to tracks and stations between Belmont and Bryn Mawr avenues by 2028, leaving 24 more years for its balance to balloon.

What to do with the money that keeps pouring in will likely be up to whomever occupies the fifth floor next term, be it Mayor Brandon Johnson or a succes-

Turn to Money, Page 4

INSIDE



The Cubs' Kyle Tucker during Thursday's game against the Brewers. **CHRIS SWEDA/TRIBUNE**

Tucker returns, but Cubs fall to Brewers

Kyle Tucker was back in the lineup on Thursday, but the Cubs lost the series finale to Brewers 4-1 in thriving rivalry. **Chicago Sports**

Israel's Gaza City offensive looms

The Israeli prime minister said he will give final approval for a takeover of Gaza City while restarting talks with Hamas. **Nation & World**

